HERIOT WATT UNIVERSITY

INFORMATION SHEET

Project title: A Grounded University Support Assistant: Retrieval-Augmented Generation with Confidence-Based Escalation

Objectives

For my Honours dissertation (F20PA/B/C) I am investigating whether a chatbot that answers student questions only from official Heriot-Watt University documents, shows its sources, and passes a question on to university staff when it is not confident, gives more accurate and trustworthy answers than simpler alternatives. I would like to ask HWU Malaysia students to try the chatbot and tell me how easy it is to use and how much they trust it. The chatbot is a research prototype and is not an official university service. The study has been designed with, and is supervised by, Dr Rosalind Deena Kumari.

The purpose of this information sheet is to explain what the study involves so that you can decide whether you want to take part. Taking part is voluntary.

Data collection

Before the session I will ask you to confirm that you are 18 years old or over, that you are a Heriot-Watt University Malaysia student, and that you feel well enough to take part. No other personal information is collected. If you are not 18 or over, you cannot take part.
During the session I will collect: (1) your answers to the questionnaire (a usability scale, trust ratings and an optional free-text comment); (2) your ratings of the chatbot answers (clear, correct, trustworthy); and (3) the text of the prepared questions and the chatbot's answers, which is stored in a log under your participant code. I do not collect video, audio, your name, student number, or any health or sensitive information. Your name and email address appear only on the consent form and the code key file.

Your data is pseudo-anonymised, not fully anonymised. Everything you provide is stored under your participant code (for example P07), not your name. The only link between your name and your code is a key file stored in a password-protected HWU OneDrive folder. The key file is deleted 2 weeks after your session. Until then you can ask me, using your participant code, to show you your data or delete it. After the key file is deleted your answers cannot be traced back to you. No names or personal details will appear in the report or any other publication, and quotes from free-text comments will only be used if they cannot identify you.

Please note that the questions you ask the chatbot are sent to a commercial large language model (LLM) service through its API in order to generate answers. I will only use the prepared questions or questions about public university information, and ask you not to mention your name, student number or any personal circumstances. I will not send the questionnaire responses, consent forms or any information that identifies you to the LLM service.

Experiment Protocol

Each session is a one-to-one meeting on Microsoft Teams and takes about 30 minutes. It is not recorded. I will share my screen and you will tell me what to ask, or choose from a short list of questions I prepared (for example about fees, deadlines or late-submission rules), so you never need to type personal information yourself. (1) A short introduction and your questions about the study (5 minutes). (2) You try the chatbot on about 5 to 8 prepared questions and tell me whether each answer is clear, correct and trustworthy (15 minutes). (3) You complete a short online questionnaire in Microsoft Forms about how easy the chatbot was to use and how much you trust it, plus an optional free-text comment (10 minutes).
A small number of participants (at most 3) will instead help me to label answers: you will read a list of question and answer pairs and mark whether each answer is correct according to the university documents. This takes about 30 minutes and is done in your own time or in a Teams call.

Safety and wellbeing: the session contains no sensitive or distressing topics, and the questions are about everyday university matters such as fees and deadlines. You can pause, skip a question or stop at any time. The chatbot is a research prototype and can make mistakes. Do not rely on its answers for real decisions: for official information please check the university website or contact the relevant university office. I will not record the session (no video, no audio and no screen recording).

What you need to do: sign and return the consent form, then join the Teams session at the agreed time, using a laptop or desktop computer with a web browser. You do not need to install anything.

Compensation

There is no payment or other compensation for taking part.

Withdraw

Taking part is completely voluntary. You can withdraw at any point during the session, without giving a reason, simply by telling me or leaving the Teams call. You can also ask me to remove your data up to 2 weeks after your session by emailing me your participant code. Withdrawing will not affect your student status, your grades or your relationship with Heriot-Watt University in any way.

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If you decide to take part, sign the consent form as described above and email it to me. Keep a copy of this information sheet. Signing the form does not commit you to anything you do not wish to do.

After I receive your signed consent form I will give you a participant code (for example P07) and agree a time for a one-to-one session on Microsoft Teams. The consent form is stored separately from your answers. The only link between your name and your code is a key file kept in a password-protected HWU OneDrive folder. I will delete this key file after the withdrawal deadline, which is 2 weeks after your session. After that date your answers can no longer be traced back to you or removed.

Please note that your signed consent form will be securely stored in the HWU One-Drive folder, which is password protected and can be accessed only by the MACS Director of Ethics and HWU Data Protection Officer.

For additional details or to request the deletion of your data, you can reach out to mba2022@hw.ac.uk or you can contact the project supervisor, Dr Rosalind Deena Kumari, via R.Kumari@hw.ac.uk. Please quote your participant code (not your name) when asking for your data to be deleted.

NOTE: Please find below further information on Heriot-Watt Data Protection

1) Data Protection Officer contact details: dataprotection@hw.ac.uk

2) Here is the ink to the Heriot-Watt University Privacy Notice for Research Participants: https://www.hw.ac.uk/uk/services/docs/information-governance/PrivacyNoticeResearch-V4Finalversion.pdf

3) Data controller is Heriot-Watt University